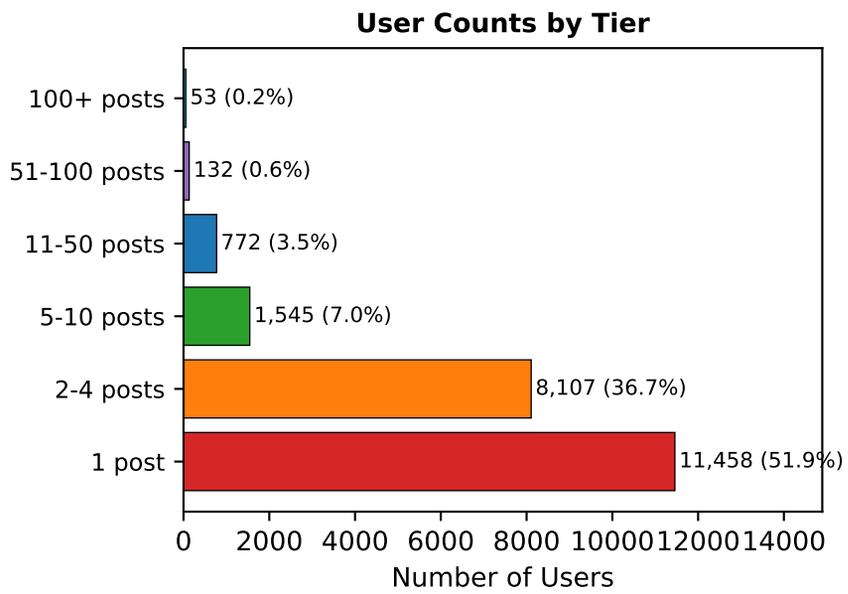
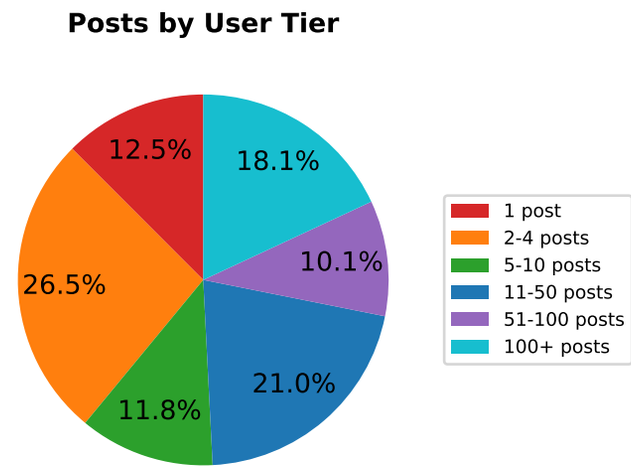
User Participation Inequality: The 88.6% Rule
Most users ask once and leave; a handful sustain the commons



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PARTICIPATION INEQUALITY
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THE 88.6% RULE
Light users (1-4 posts):  88.6%
Active users (5-100):     10.5%
Super users (100+):        0.9%

CONTENT CONCENTRATION
Top 1 user:    37% of r/CUNY
Top 10 users:  63% of all content
Top 1%:        41% of all posts

FRAGILITY INDICATOR
If top 10 users leave,
community loses majority
of knowledge production.

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"The commons depends on
 a handful of stewards"
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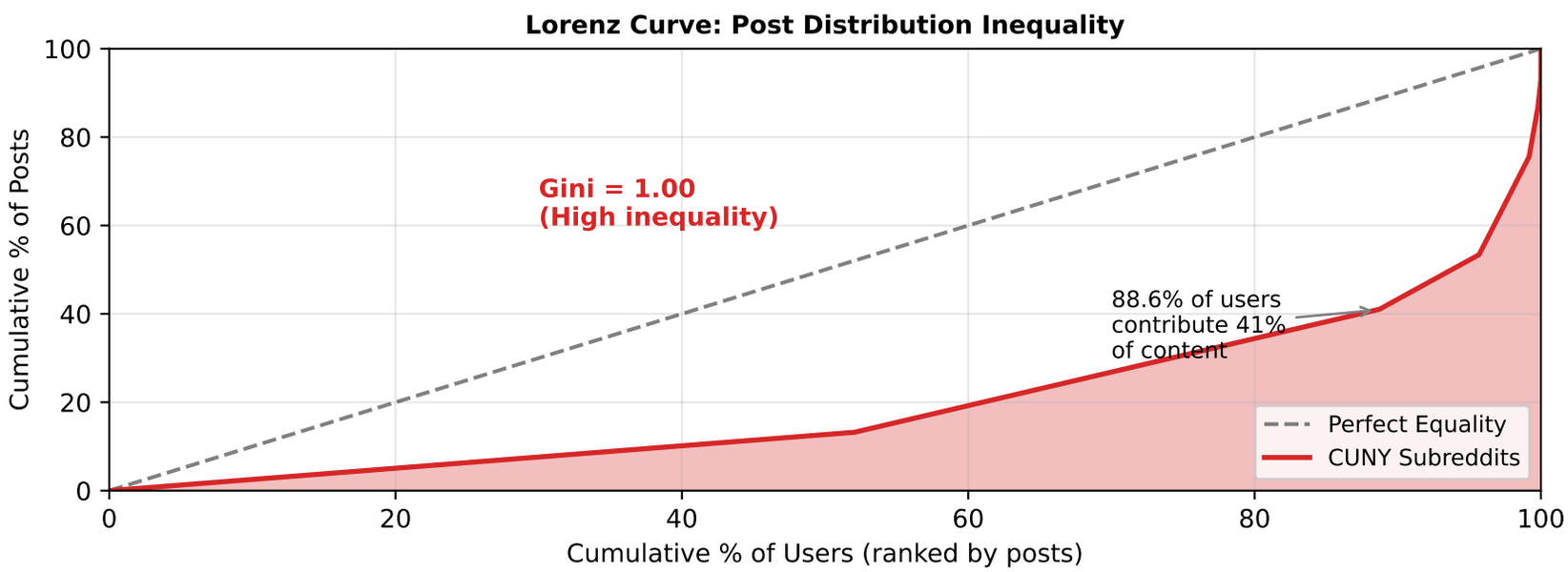

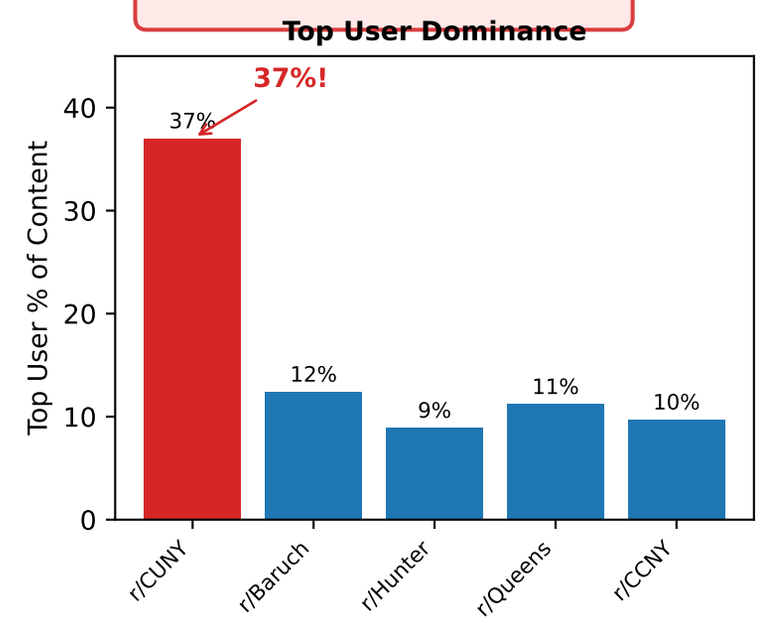

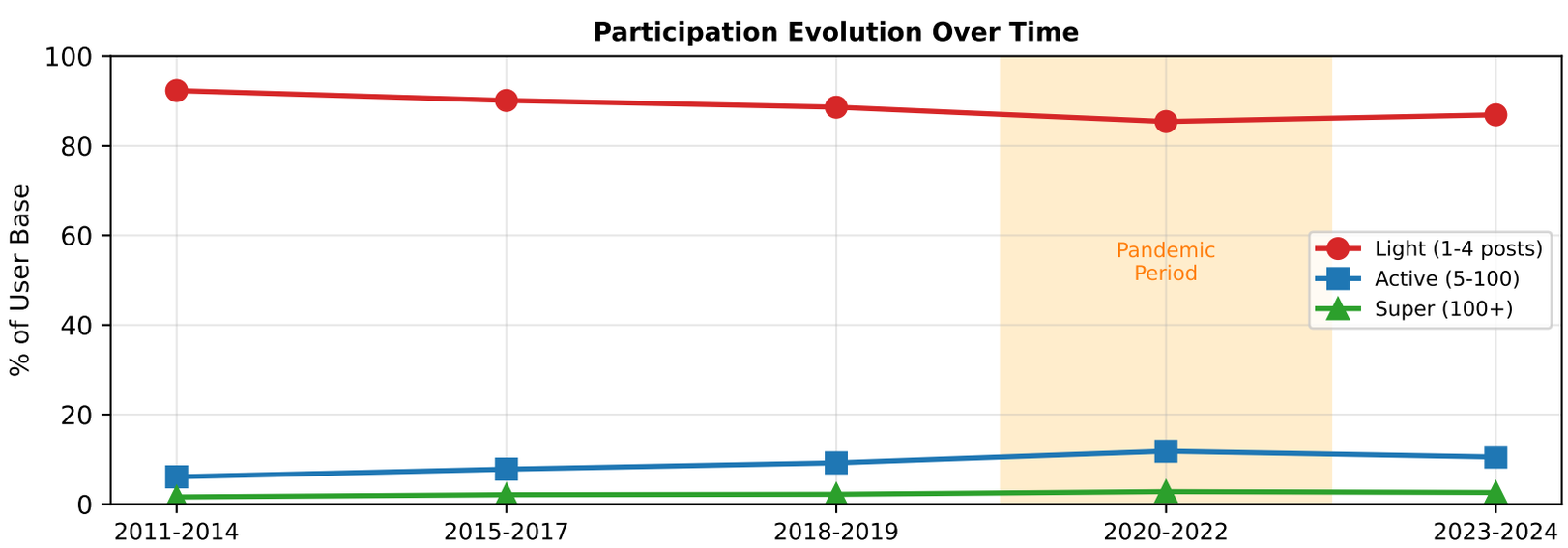


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IMPLICATIONS FOR
KNOWLEDGE COMMONS
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FRAGILITY
• Community depends on
  tiny elite of contributors
• Loss of super-users could
  collapse knowledge production

RESILIENCE
• Pandemic diversified
  participation (briefly)
• More active users emerged
  during crisis

DESIGN INSIGHT
• Most users are readers
• Knowledge extraction ≠
  knowledge contribution
• "Lurking" is valid
  participation mode

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Framework: Ostrom (1990)
"Governing the Commons"
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